MCP

Title:

A.I. Speechbot

Author:

Forrest Musselman

© 2024 Forrest Musselman
Publication Date: December 1, 2024

Published by

MUSHROOM CLOUD PRESS

An imprint of Rainbow Skull LLC

Made in the USA

Permission for performance of this piece is granted for the purpose of performance in competition by middle school, high school, and undergraduate collegiate performers. Online, remote, and video performances are permitted for these purposes only. Video or audio recordings of performances may not be shared or posted online without permission from the publisher. Theatrical performance and all other kinds of public performance, whether broadcast, online, or on stage, are prohibited without prior written permission from Mushroom Cloud Press, an imprint of Rainbow Skull LLC.

This script is authorized for competition only if the competitor or the competitor's representative, including but not limited to parent or educational entity, has purchased a copy of the script from Mushroom Cloud Press or an authorized retailer. The script must be presented with the cover sheet bearing the ISBN. Additional requirements for performance may be made by tournament and league rules.

Tournament officials: please contact Mushroom Cloud Press to validate script purchase.

For all inquiries and to see our full catalog of scripts, visit

MushroomCloudPress.com

(Production Note: This piece can be performed in either the Humorous category or Duo Interpretation category in speech. Feel free to add or substitute any sounds, poses, and transitions that work best with your talents.)

ROB

(typing noises) That's it! That's the last of the uploads.

GRACE

(Clicking pen noises- scribbling on notepad) Perfect! We've done it, Bob! After years of hard-driven data, after years of attending countless speech tournaments, after years of soul-sucking boredom, we have created the perfect A I Speech Bot for the category Humorous Interpretation. (or Duo).

(Snap to A I Speech Bot standing in the perfect speech pose carrying a backpack.)

ROB

This is amazing, Grace! I have to admit, when I first let you talk me into taking this job at National Speech Laboratories, I was highly skeptical. In fact, I didn't like the idea at all. But you were right. Competitive Speech can be data driven and formulaic. And now with the unregulated insurgence of artificial intelligence, we have created the perfect forensic machine.

GRACE

You know, it was only a matter of time before there was a speech bot. Look at the other speech categories. I mean, Extemp. Speaking is almost there already. Just a bunch of animatronic drones.

ROB

No kidding. And Great Speeches? (Mimics in robot voice) I will walk here and recite speech. I will walk here and analyze speech. I will walk here and recite speech. I will walk here and analyze speech. I will walk here…

GRACE

(Has had enough) Raaaaaaaahhhhhhhhhhb! I get it. Nothing but droids… all of them. That's why in a world where competitive speech has been simplified to perfected repetition, we have created the ultimate weapon. Soon we will amass a speech team so perfect we will dominate our section, our state, nationals and then the world. I mean, look at her.

(Snap to A I Speech Bot standing in the perfect speech pose carrying a backpack.)

GRACE

The brand new power suit. Could be black with a splash of color. Could be color with a splash of black. The hair tied back to show she means business. The shoes are stylish but made to move.

(Snap to A I Speech Bot standing in the perfect speech pose carrying a backpack.)

ROB

The backpack full of the important necessities needed for the day. Mangled crumpled script on construction paper. The ever important water bottle for between rounds hydration. Various snacks, pills, and lotions. A notebook to scribble mindless doodles in during other competitor's presentations. And most importantly, the lint roller.

(Snap to A I Speech Bot standing in the perfect speech pose, lint rolling herself in a manic fashion, while making a lint rolling sound… of course.)

GRACE

(Has had enough) Raaaaaaaahhhhhhhhhhb! What is she doing?

ROB

(Typing manically) Sorry, just a little glitch with the lint roller. She appears to be spotless now.

(Snap to A.I. Speech Bot standing in perfect speech pose with backpack.)

(If you do an introduction, you can insert it here.)

GRACE

Okay, let's give this A.I. Speech Bot a test run. Let's start with the snaps.

ROB

You mean the pops?

GRACE

No, I mean the snaps.

ROB

Pops.

GRACE

SNAPS!

ROB

Okay. (typing) Here we go. We'll start with the feet.

(Snap to A.I. Speech Bot standing in perfect speech pose. She suddenly moves feet in and out quickly, but not moving the rest of her body.)

GRACE

Great. Now add the rest of the standard characterization poses. Child with backpack.

(A.I. Speech Bot does. Feel free to insert or replace other stereotypical characters.)

GRACE

Stupid bimbo.

(A.I. Speech Bot does.)

GRACE

Maniacal evil person.

(A.I. Speech Bot does.)

GRACE

Superhero.

(A.I. Speech Bot does.)

GRACE

Old person

(A.I. Speech Bot does.)

GRACE

Nerd.

(A.I. Speech Bot does.)

GRACE

Run them again.

(A.I. Speech Bot runs all poses quickly as possible but can't stop.)

GRACE

(Has had enough) Raaaaaaaahhhhhhhhhhb! What is she doing? My god, you're driving me to drink beer. (Makes sound of opening can. Chugs it.)

ROB

Sorry. Just another glitch. (Typing) Nothing that SpeechWire can't fix. Moving on to sound effects. Should we start with opening the door?

A.I. SPEECH BOT

(Opens) Chicka- errrrr! (Closes) Errrr-chicka. (Opens) Chicka-errrr! (Closes) Errrr-chicka.

GRACE

No. Why is she saying "chicka"? If you turn a door knob, it doesn't go "chicka." And why is the door squeaky? And why is she closing the door? You never close a door in speech.

ROB

You're right, dear. Let's try this.

A.I. SPEECH BOT

(Opens) Chicka- door. Chicka- door.

GRACE

That's worse.

A.I. SPEECH BOT

(Mimes opening a door with no sound.)

GRACE

Even worse. Go back to Chicka-door. Let's move on. Cell phone.

(A.I. Speech Bot does. Again, feel free to insert or replace any sound effects you like.)

GRACE

Turning pages in a book.

(A.I. Speech Bot does.)

GRACE

Spray bottle.

(A.I. Speech Bot does.)

GRACE

Shaving cream.

(A.I. Speech Bot does.)

GRACE

Beat box.

(A.I. Speech Bot does.)

GRACE

Run them again.

(A.I. Speech Bot runs all sounds quickly as possible but can't stop. Throws some other random sounds as well.)

GRACE

(Has had enough) Raaaaaaaahhhhhhhhhhb! What is she doing? My god, you're driving me to hard liquor. (Pops cork, makes glug, glug pouring sound, slams drink or make a martini.)

ROB

Just a little snafu in the coding. (Typing) Already taken care of. Nothing to worry about.

GRACE

Hmmm, I'm beginning to wonder. Let's move on to transition sounds.

ROB

Yes! I love transition sounds. What better way to show a passage of time or scene transition than through sound.

GRACE

Exactly. What do we have?

(A. I. Bot makes weird breathing sound that starts quietly and then builds and stops abruptly.)

GRACE

What was that?

(A. I. Bot makes weird breathing sound that starts quietly and then builds and stops abruptly.)

GRACE

That's the stupidest sound I've ever heard.

ROB

But they're all doing it.

GRACE

What are we…sheep?

(A.I. Bot baas like a sheep.)

GRACE

What else do we have?

(A.I. Bot goes through a litany of sounds and movements: spins, jumps, etc. Have fun!)

GRACE

(Has had enough) Raaaaaaahhhhhhbbbbbbb!!! That's it. I've heard enough. My god, you're driving me smoke. (Goes through process of getting a cigarette, lighting it, smoking, flicking to ground, snuffing it out with the foot.)

ROB

I think we've got it all covered now. Quick body transitions, appropriate sound effects and creative transitions.

GRACE

Let's now progress to the full speech performance.

ROB

Yeah, about that.

GRACE

Stop talking. Keep typing. Make sure she starts with the audience death stare.

ROB

(Makes some typing noises)

(A. I. Bot stands at attention. She slowly surveys the audience with a confident death stare. She does a time transition sound, knocks on a door, opens a door and steps in. She selects a book, opens it, leafs through some pages. She attempts to speak. Nothing. She attempts to speak again. Nothing.)

GRACE

Speech Bot! Why aren't you speaking? Raaaaaaahhhhhhbbbbbbb!!!

ROB

There isn't a speech.

GRACE

Why?

ROB

We've spent all our time on everything else. I actually haven't got to the speech yet. In fact, is that the whole point of speech? To speak?

GRACE

What sort of blasphemy is this?

ROB

I say down with the data. Why are we spending so much time on movements and sound effects and transitions when the real focus should be on the speech itself?

GRACE

You're fired. That is not the future of forensics. If you don't have the right look and the right movements and sound effects, then what do you have?

ROB

A speech. (Typing) That's it. I'm pulling the plug. (More typing)

(A.I. Speech Bot starts shaking and making weird noises. She finally explodes.)

GRACE

Raaaaaaahhhhhhbbbbbbb!!!

END